

Challenge Your English

Ready to challenge your English? This lesson will test your skills across three levels: beginner, intermediate and advanced. You'll answer 12 questions, accompanied by 12 short lessons to explain each answer. Have a go at them all at once or take your time with it. This isn't exactly a 'level test' but it is a fun way to see what you know. Let's put your English knowledge to the test!

Beginner: A1 /A2

Are you ready for your first test?

Before we get started, let me give you a quick introduction to the beginner English level. At this stage, you should be able to handle basic communication in English. This includes exchanging simple greetings, asking and answering personal questions and understanding familiar words and phrases. You should be able to express yourself in simple sentences about familiar topics like your family or daily routines.

Alright, it's time for the first question.

1 Choose the correct option to fill in the gap.

There aren't _____ books on the table.

- a. some
- b. any

The answer is '**any**' - **There aren't any books on the table.**

We usually use 'any' in negative sentences with plural or uncountable nouns.

Let's move on to question 2!

2

Fill in the gaps to create a question in the present simple tense.
Use the verb 'to like'.

_____ he _____ olives? (like)

Here's the answer: **Does he like olives?**

Did you get that? To make yes/no questions in the present simple, we often use '**do**' or '**does**'—we used 'does' here because the subject is 'he'. The verb is in the base form—'like'—not 'likes'.

I often see students at the beginner and pre-intermediate levels confuse expressions with 'like' due to their similarities in wording but differences in meaning:

- **What do/does [sb.] like?** This question asks about preferences or interests.
- **What is/are [sb.] like?** This is a question about personality or character traits. It asks for a description of someone's nature or behaviour.
- **What do/does [sb.] look like?** This question is about physical appearance. It seeks a description of someone's physical attributes.

3

Fill in the gap using the correct form of the word 'easy' to compare English to German.

I think English is _____ than German.

The answer is easier -

I think English is easier than German.



Did you spell that right?

When a one- or two-syllable adjective ends in a **consonant + y**, we usually make the comparative by **removing the 'y'** and **adding 'ier'**:

- **easy** - **easier**
- **pretty** - **prettier**

Let's look at sentence 4. This is the last one at A1 and A2.

4

Choose the correct option to fill in the gap.

Oh, no! He _____ that mirror. Watch out!

- a. will break
- b. is going to break
- c. is breaking

Here's the answer: **'is going to break'** - **Oh, no! He is going to break that mirror. Watch out!**

We use **'to be going to'** to make predictions based on evidence we have now - often evidence we can see.

How did you do on that section? Are you ready to move on to B1 and B2-level questions?

Intermediate: B1/B2

At B2, you are expected to understand and engage in conversations on a variety of topics. This includes following the main points in clear standard speech and expressing personal opinions on familiar subjects. You should have the ability to discuss a range of topics with supporting opinions.

5

Find the mistake and correct it.

Have you ever been to Tokyo?

Yes, I've been in 2019.

Did you find it?

The mistake was using '**I've been**', which is the present perfect simple tense, with a specific time reference - '**in 2019**'. If you want to use a specific time reference, you should use the past simple: 'I went in 2019.' You could also remove the time reference from the sentence.

- **Have you ever been to Tokyo?**
- **Yes, I've been.**

It would be more natural to say, 'Yes, I have', but 'Yes, I've been' is OK.

Let's look at question 6.

6

Choose the correct option to fill in the gap.

I finally got round to _____ that film you recommended.

- a. watch
- b. watched
- c. watching

The answer is watching. '**To get round/around to**' is a phrasal verb meaning to find the time to do something. It can be followed by a gerund (an -ing verb) or a noun, pronoun or noun phrase.

A **gerund** is a verb form that ends in **-ing** and functions as a noun in a sentence.



Verbs with Gerunds: Some verbs are always followed by a gerund.

- I **enjoy** **cooking**.
- She **avoids** **going** to crowded places.

Verbs with Nouns: Many verbs need a noun after them.

You **need** **permission**.

They **want** **a new house**.

Verbs with Both: Some verbs can have either a noun or a gerund after them.

I like **chocolate**.

I like **swimming**.

Let's look at question 7.

7

Which word forms the best collocation with 'a reputation for something'?

Colin has _____ a reputation for being very stubborn in negotiations.

- a. constructed
- b. gained
- c. achieved

The answer is '**gained**' - **Colin has **gained** a reputation for being very stubborn in negotiations.**

'To gain a reputation for something' is a strong collocation. We wouldn't usually say 'constructed' or 'achieved' a reputation. Now, here's the final question in our B1-B2 section.

8

Fill in the gaps to complete the sentence. Use the verbs in brackets.

If the weather _____ (be) better yesterday, we _____ (eat) outdoors. However, it was pouring, so we ate inside.

Answer: **If the weather *had been better* yesterday, we *would have eaten* outdoors.**

This is a **third conditional sentence**. The structure is -

if + past perfect, would have + past participle.

We use the third conditional to **imagine a different past**. It's a hypothetical conditional because we can't change the past.

Right, that's the end of our B1/B2 intermediate section.

Advanced: C1/C2

Now, at the advanced level of English, you should have a strong command of the language and be able to use it flexibly and effectively for social, academic and professional purposes. This includes understanding a wide range of demanding, longer texts and recognising implicit meaning. You should also be able to express ideas fluently and spontaneously without much obvious searching for expressions.

Are you ready for the advanced-level test?

9

Think of one word to fill in the blank in all three sentences. The word must be exactly the same.

- I was at a _____ as to how to help.
- The _____ of his mother hit Erik hard.
- We made a _____ during our first year in business.

Ready for the answer? **loss**

- I was at a **loss** as to how to help.
- The **loss** of his mother hit Erik hard.
- We made a **loss** during our first year in business.

If you are '**at a loss**', you don't know what to do or say. That's in the first sentence. In the second sentence, 'loss' means the death of a person. In the third sentence, 'loss' means the money a business lost and is the opposite of 'profit'.

Both 'at a loss' and 'to make a loss' are strong collocations in English

Alright, let's move on to the next one. This is a high-level vocabulary question.

10

Choose the correct option to fill in the gap.

The singer had a wonderfully _____ voice that was perfect for jazz.

- a. gruff
- b. husky
- c. hoarse

The answer is **'husky'**.

The singer had a wonderfully husky voice that was perfect for jazz.

'Gruff', 'husky' and 'hoarse' have similar meanings; we can use them all to describe the sound of someone's voice.

However, **'gruff'** usually has a negative connotation - a gruff voice is low, deep and sometimes unfriendly.

'Hoarse' also has a negative connotation — if someone's voice is hoarse, it's rough and unpleasant, often because someone has a sore throat.

A **'husky voice'** is also low and rough, but it's often in an attractive way. It's essential to know these nuances in meaning when you get to an advanced level in English.

Let's look at question 11. You might recognise this question type from English exams.

11

Use the word 'brink' to fill in the gap and make the second sentence mean the same as the first. Do not change the word 'brink'. You can use between 3 and 6 words in the gap.

Sentence 1: Medical advances should soon produce a breakthrough in gene therapy.

Sentence 2: The medical community is thought _____ a breakthrough in gene therapy. (BRINK)

Ready for the answer?

The medical community is thought to be on the brink of a breakthrough in gene therapy.

Did you get that? If you are '**on the brink of**' something, a new or different situation is about to begin. It implies something is going to happen or someone is going to do something in the very near future. It can be used in both positive and negative situations.

- **Positive:** used with an optimistic or beneficial event, it highlights anticipation and potential.
 - *The agency is on the brink of signing in a huge client.*
- **Negative:** refers to a potentially harmful or undesirable event expressing a sense of impending danger or threat.
 - *They are on the brink of bankruptcy.*

There was also an impersonal passive structure in that sentence - '**The medical community is thought to be**'. The impersonal passive is used to express general opinions or beliefs without specifying who holds them. Here we are saying 'the medical community' in general but not who in particular.

We can form the impersonal passive in two ways:

it + be + past participle + (that) + subject + verb

It is known that the library closes at 8 PM.

someone/something + be + past participle + infinitive

She is believed to be the best candidate for the position.

Now, onto the final question.

12

Change the form of the word in capital letters so it fits in the gap.

The city was _____ by large stone walls. (CIRCLE)

The answer is 'encircled' - **The city was encircled by large stone walls.**

This question was all about word formation. In this case, we took the word 'circle' and made it into a past participle by adding **-d** and we added the prefix 'en'.

To 'encircle' means 'to surround completely'. We wouldn't say 'circled' - that means moving in a circle or drawing a circle around something.

Here are a few more examples:

- The ancient statue was **encircled** by a newly constructed fence to protect it from being damaged.
- Large trees **encircled** the property, giving the garden plenty of shade.
- The man eating a bag of crisps near the water was **encircled** by seagulls.

Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. Which sentence uses the impersonal passive?
- a. It is expected that the new policies will improve market conditions.

b. The new policies are expected to improve the market conditions.

c. They expect the new policies to improve market conditions.
2. Select the correct way to ask about someone's habits in the present simple.
- a. Does he plays tennis at the weekends?

b. Do he play tennis at the weekends?

c. Does he play tennis at the weekends?
3. Choose the sentence that correctly uses the third conditional.
- a. If it rains, we will stay home.

b. If it had rained, we would have stayed home.

c. If it would rain, we stayed home.

Choose the words from the word bank to complete each sentence.

a. encircled	b. husky	c. on the brink of	d. got around to	e. any
--------------	----------	--------------------	------------------	--------

4. After delaying his visit to the dentist for months, John finally _____ making an appointment.
5. It is believed that the climate summit is _____ achieving a significant breakthrough.
6. The castle was _____ by a vast moat that stopped invaders during ancient times.
7. We haven't seen _____ birds in the garden this winter.
8. When he speaks in a low, slightly rough voice, it sounds rather _____, which is quite appealing.

Answers:

1) a 2) c 3) b 4) d 5) c 6) a 7) e 8) b

